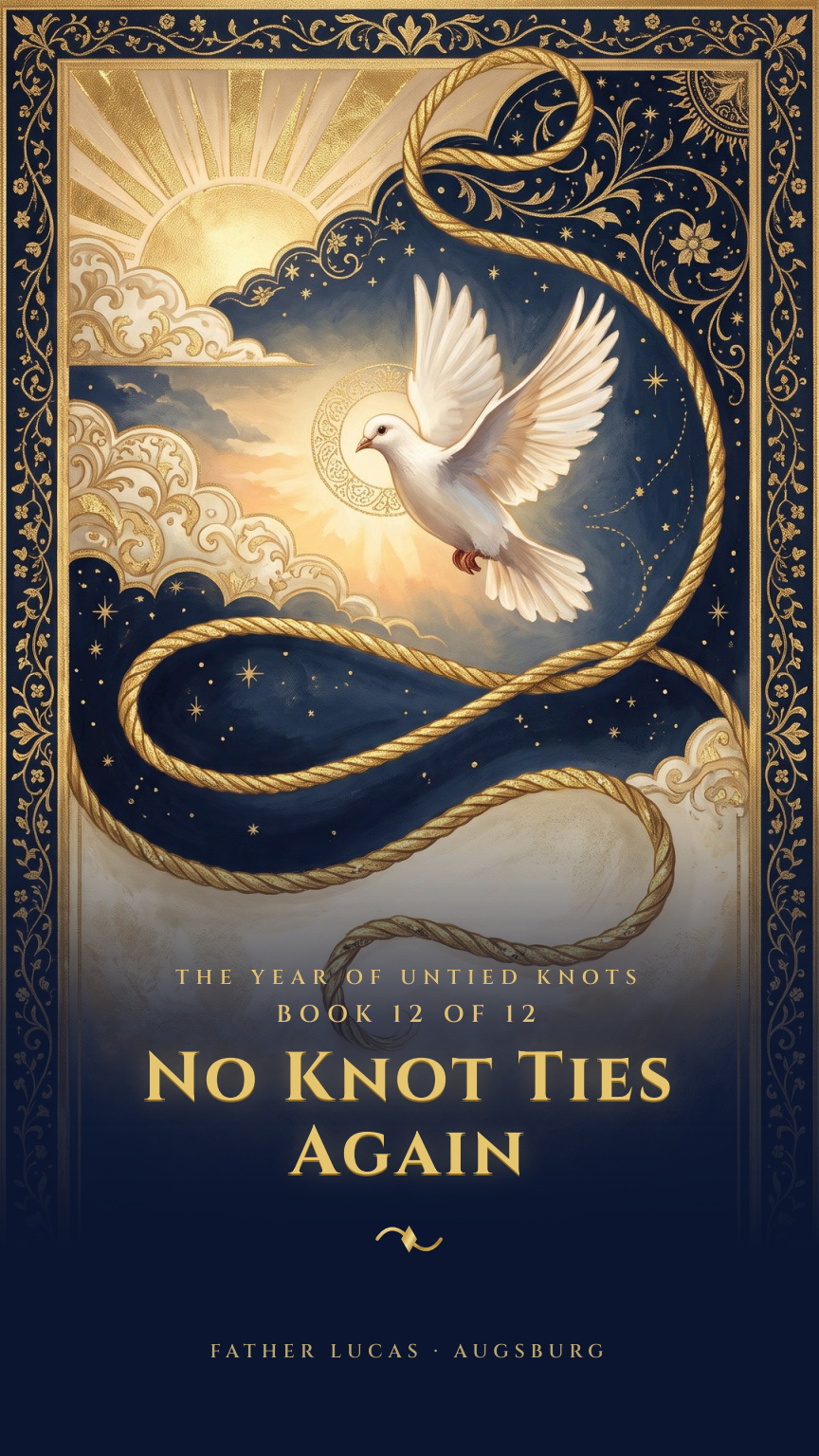


THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 12 OF 12

No Knot Ties Again

FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For the year behind you, and for the mornings still to come. No knot ties again.



Father Lucas



BOOK 12

This book: Review of the nine knots, a rule of life, and a legacy: that no knot ties again.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

BOOK 12

The Year of Untied Knots · Days 337 to 365 · Book 12 of 12

The knot: All nine, in review, and surrender

Month motto: The thread stays loose where the hands keep touching it.

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

Good morning, my friend. You're holding the last month. If you've come all this way, you know something I didn't know when I began: a knot is rarely undone once. It's undone, and then it's kept undone, one small morning at a time.

This month we go back to each of the nine. First we look, honestly, at how the knot sits now. Then we choose the small habit that keeps it loose. In the last ten days we turn to the house, and to the people who will live in it after us.

Nobody finishes a year of prayer a perfect person. They finish it a faithful one. Go gently. I'm glad you're here.

Father Lucas

BOOK 12

THE MAP OF THE MONTH

Week 1 (Days 337–343): One breath for the year. Health, money, and marriage, each looked at honestly, then kept loose.

Week 2 (Days 344–350): The one you wait for, your children, and your work. Then the splinter in forgiveness.

Week 3 (Days 351–357): Warm water, a quiet house, an open hand, and the first words of the day. You write your rule and choose your corner.

Week 4 (Days 358–365): Teaching a child to pray, passing on a page, a blessing for the house, thanks, a letter to next year, and day 365.

BOOK 12

THREE PROMISES FOR THE MONTH

I. *I will look at each knot as it is, not as I fear it.*

II. *I will keep one small habit for each knot.*

III. *I will pass one page to someone who needs it.*

IV. --

Psalm of the month: 150 — "Let everything that has breath praise Yah."

MY NAME



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WEEK 1

One breath for the year

DAYS 337 TO 343

Health, money, and marriage, each looked at honestly, then kept loose.



DAY 337

One Year in One Breath

who remembered us in our low estate, for his loving kindness endures forever; and has delivered us from our adversaries, for his loving kindness endures forever;

PSALM 136:23–24 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Look at the pages in your hands. The corners are soft now. There's a coffee ring on one, maybe a crease on another.

That's a year. Not a year of perfect mornings. A year of showing up with a tired face and an open page. I didn't do it perfectly either. I skipped days. I came back.

This last month, we walk back through all nine knots, one at a time. Not to untie them again. Only to see how they sit now, and how to keep them loose. Today, we just breathe. Mary has counted your mornings. She hasn't missed one.

Mary, it's early and the house is still. I'm holding a whole year in this one breath. The mornings I came, and the mornings I didn't. Thank you for never keeping score. Walk with me back through the nine knots this month. Show me what has loosened, and what still needs your fingers. I'm not afraid to look. Amen.



TODAY

Sit with the page closed in your lap. Breathe in once, slowly, for everything this year held. Breathe out once, for everything you've set down.

☐ DONE

What have I set down this year that I thought I'd carry forever?

PSALM

136 — "his loving kindness endures forever"; the psalm that thanks God for a long road, one line at a time.



DAY 338

The Stairs, Counted Again

Gray hair is a crown of glory. It is attained by a life of righteousness.

PROVERBS 16:31 (WEB)

Think about your stairs. Or the front steps, or the curb outside the pharmacy. A year ago, how did you take them? And how do you take them now?

I'm not asking so you can count what you've lost. The body keeps a quiet record, and it deserves to be read kindly. Maybe you're slower. Maybe you're steadier than you feared. Maybe the news you dreaded came, and you're still standing in your own kitchen.

Either way, Mary rode home with you from the doctor's, even when you felt alone. She isn't afraid of this body. She looks at it with love.

Mary, here are my knees, my heart, my eyes, my back. They've carried me a long way. Thank you for what still works. Stay very close to what hurts. When hard news comes, send someone to hold my hand. And on the good days, teach me to say thank you before I say "if only." Amen.



TODAY

Write two lines. First, one thing about your body that's harder than a year ago. Second, one thing it still does for you.

☐ DONE

What would I say to my body if it were an old friend?

PSALM

71 — "don't forsake me when my strength fails"; the psalm for an aging body and an honest heart.



DAY 339

One Line on the Mirror

In the day that I called, you answered me. You encouraged me with strength in my soul.

PSALM 138:3 (WEB)

Here's a secret about keeping a knot loose. It likes company in the parts of the day you already do without thinking. Brushing your teeth. Washing your face. Reaching for your glasses.

So give your health a place to be prayed over, right where you already stand every morning. One line on the bathroom mirror. Not a long prayer. Just a reminder that you aren't alone in this body.

When you see it, your eyes stop for a second. In that second, Mary slips her hand under yours. Nothing is asked of you except to look up from the sink.

Gentle Mother, I'm standing at the sink with my hair a mess. You see me like this, and you don't look away. Bless this body I wash each morning. Bless the hands that hold the toothbrush and the cup. Keep the fear small and the thanks plain. Stay with me through the long hours. Amen.



TODAY

Tape one small line to your bathroom mirror, in your own handwriting: "Be gentle with the body that got you here."

☐ DONE

Where else in my day could one small line catch my eye?

PSALM

138 — "you encouraged me with strength in my soul"; the psalm of a person who was answered on the day they called. (Changed from 90.)



DAY 340

Your Hand on the Pile



Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest.

MATTHEW 11:28 (WEB)

Let's look at the money knot again. A year ago, you could hardly face the pile on the table. Today you can at least say what's in it. That isn't nothing. That's a loosened thread.

The pile may still be there. I won't pretend it isn't. Remember the jar of oil, from Book 2? It was never full. It was always just enough for the next day.

Shame is the part that has to go. Shame says the pile is who you are. It isn't. It's paper. You are someone Mary knows by name.

Our Lady, here is the pile, and here is my hand on it. I won't hide it from you, and I won't let it speak for me. Give me a clear mind when I open the next one. Give me courage to ask when I should ask. And let me sleep tonight, whatever the total says. Amen.



TODAY

Gather all of this month's bills into one pile. Lay your hand flat on top for ten seconds. Say, "You are paper. I am Mary's child."

☐ DONE

What has the pile been telling me about myself that isn't true?

PSALM

123 — "have mercy on us"; the psalm of a person tired of feeling small over money.



DAY 341

A Dish by the Door

In nothing be anxious, but in everything, by prayer and petition with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God.

PHILIPPIANS 4:6 (WEB)

Bills don't arrive on a schedule that suits you. They come on bad days and tired days, and you open them standing in your coat. That's how fear sneaks in.

So give the mail one place to land. A small dish by the door, or a corner of the counter. Then make a rule, a kind one. Before you open anything, you pause. One breath, one line: "Give us this day."

It takes five seconds. But it changes who opens the letter: a frightened person, or someone who prayed first. Same paper. Different hands.

Lord Jesus, you taught me to ask for today and nothing more. Here is today's mail on the counter. Before I open it, stand beside me. Whatever it says, let me read it with a steady heart. Show me the one small step that is mine to take, and keep me from taking ten. Amen.



TODAY

Set a small dish or tray where the mail lands. Lay your rosary or a holy card beside it, so you pray before you open anything.

☐ DONE

What am I most afraid to find in the mail?

PSALM

146 — "the LORD raises up those who are bowed down"; the psalm for a person who braces at the mailbox.



DAY 342

Three Small Things You Still Love

bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, and endures all things.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:7 (WEB)

Some of you share a house with a husband or a wife. Some of you share it now with a memory. This day is for both.

A year ago, the knot was cold, or lonely. Maybe it still is. But look closer. Is there one thing left? The way he hums at the stove. The way she holds a cup with both hands. The sound of a key in the door, or the memory of that sound.

Love lives in small things like that. You don't have to feel the whole marriage today. Only these three. Mary keeps all of them safe.

Lord, you built this house, so I'll start by trusting it to you. Thank you for the small things I'd almost stopped seeing. A step in the hall. A warm hand on a shoulder. Where it's hard, keep my tongue gentle. Where the one I love is gone, keep the love from going cold. Amen.



TODAY

Write three small things you still love about your husband or wife, or about the one you miss. One line each, in plain words.

☐ DONE

When did I last say one of these three out loud to them?

PSALM

127 — "unless the LORD builds the house"; the psalm for a home held up by more than one pair of hands.



DAY 343

The Sentence They Already Know

A word fitly spoken is like apples of gold in settings of silver.

PROVERBS 25:11 (WEB)

Most couples go years without saying the plainest thing. We assume it's known. "Of course he knows." "She knows I do." But a sentence left unsaid is a thread left on the floor. Someone trips on it eventually.

So today, say it. "I'm glad it's you." Or "Thank you for the coffee." It doesn't need to be poetry. Say it in your kitchen voice. If your husband or wife has gone ahead of you, say it to the room. Mary hears it, and so do they.

A kind word kept in the mouth does no one any good.

Lord Jesus, you went to a wedding once, so you know what a home costs. Here is mine. Loosen my pride, and give me one true, gentle sentence to say today. Let it be small enough to say and warm enough to stay. Where I can't say it to a person, let it reach them anyway. Amen.



TODAY

Say it out loud today: "I'm glad it's you." Say it to your husband or wife, or to the empty room, in your plainest voice.

☐ DONE

What sentence have I been assuming someone already knows?

PSALM

128 — "may you see your children's children"; the psalm of a household that stays kind.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A word you skip today is easier to skip tomorrow. Love stays soft the way a knot does, with small touches, kept up. One kind sentence a day is plenty.



WEEK 2

Week 2

DAYS 344 TO 350

The one you wait for, your children, and your work. Then the splinter in forgiveness.



DAY 344

The Name in Your Phone



Turn again, we beg you, God of Armies. Look down from heaven, and see, and visit this vine,

PSALM 80:14 (WEB)

You know the name. It sits in your phone, and your thumb knows the way there even when you don't press it.

A year has gone by. Maybe they called. Maybe they didn't. I won't make that smaller than it is. The waiting is its own kind of work, and you've done it well.

But look at what the waiting has done to your picture of them. Is it only the hurt now? Today, remember one other thing. A laugh. A silly hat. The way they ran down the driveway. Love needs a memory to stand on when the phone is quiet.

Mother Mary, you know the name I carry. I give it to you again, with no speech and no plan. If I've been hard, soften me. If I've been waiting angry, loosen it. Keep them safe wherever they are tonight. And when the phone rings, or when it doesn't, let my heart be ready. Amen.



TODAY

Write one happy memory of the one you wait for, in a single sentence. Begin with "I remember when..." and keep it for them.

☐ DONE

What did they love that I have forgotten to remember?

PSALM

80 — "turn again... visit this vine"; the psalm of a parent asking God to go where they cannot.



DAY 345

The Name at the Kettle

The LORD is good to those who wait for him, to the soul who seeks him. It is good that a man should hope and quietly wait for the salvation of the LORD.

LAMENTATIONS 3:25–26 (WEB)

Waiting is hard on the body. It sits in your shoulders and wakes you early. So give it a job. A small, daily one.

Choose a moment you never skip. For me, it's the kettle. While the water heats, I say one name, out loud, and nothing else. Not a speech. Not a plan. Just the name, held up toward Mary like a cup.

Fifty seconds, give or take. And here's what I've noticed. The waiting stays, but it stops being heavy. It becomes a place where someone is kept, instead of a place where you stand.

Mary, here is the kettle, and here is the name. I say it, and I put it in your hands. You know the rest. You know what I'd say if my voice didn't shake. Carry it where I can't go. Hold them in your own way and your own time. And hold me while I wait. Amen.



TODAY

Say the name of the one you wait for out loud while the kettle heats. Then add only: "Mary, you know the rest."

☐ DONE

What would it feel like to wait without bracing?

PSALM

130 — "my soul waits for the Lord more than watchmen for the morning"; the psalm of patient waiting.



DAY 346

The Wallet Photo

His offspring will be mighty in the land. The generation of the upright will be blessed.

PSALM 112:2 (WEB)

Take out your wallet. Or the frame from the shelf. Find the oldest photo of your child. The small one, the gap-toothed one, the corners worn soft from your thumb.

That child grew up. They have their own keys and their own mistakes. And somewhere in this past year, you probably learned again how little of it is yours to steer.

That doesn't make you less of a parent. It makes you an honest one. What's left in your hands is the best part: the praying. No one grows too old to be prayed for. Mary doesn't hand children back when they turn forty.

Our Lady, I'm holding their picture, small and smiling, and I know they're grown now. I give them to you again, just as they are today, with their choices and their troubles. Cover them where I can't reach. Keep me from pushing, and from giving up. Let my love be a quiet hand on their back. Amen.



TODAY

Write each child's name on a slip of paper. Beside it, write one word for what you hope for them, not what you want them to do.

☐ DONE

What have I been steering that was never mine to steer?

PSALM

67 — "may God be merciful to us, bless us"; the psalm that asks a blessing over a whole family.



DAY 347

The Blessing at the Sink

He took them in his arms and blessed them, laying his hands on them.

MARK 10:16 (WEB)

You don't need a church for a blessing. You need a mouth and a name. Marguerite, who sings in our choir, blesses her grandchildren at the kitchen sink. Hands in the suds, voice low. "Lord, keep the little one. Lord, keep the tall one." She says it while she washes the first cup of the day.

They live three states away. They don't know she does it. But she says the house feels different now, as if the children are standing in the room, a little closer than the map says.

Say the names. Say them aloud. A spoken blessing travels farther than you'd think.

Lord, I say their names to you now, one at a time, slowly. Keep them in the morning and keep them at night. Keep them when they're laughing and when they're alone. Hold their steps steady and their hearts soft. I can't follow them everywhere. You're already there. Keep them close to you, and close to me. Amen.



TODAY

While you wash a cup or a plate, say each child's and grandchild's name aloud. After each one, add: "Lord, keep them."

☐ DONE

Whose name do I say most easily, and whose do I skip?

PSALM

78 — "we will not hide them from their children"; the psalm of a faith handed down by saying it aloud.



DAY 348

What You Made Useful

For God is not unrighteous, so as to forget your work and the labor of love which you showed toward his name, in that you served the saints, and still do serve them.

HEBREWS 6:10 (WEB)

Walt ushered at our church for thirty years. After he retired, he kept arriving early anyway, just to straighten the hymnals. "Somebody has to," he said. Nobody had asked him.

That's work too. Not the kind with a paycheck. The kind that makes a place a little more ready for the people who'll come.

Think about this past year. Not a job title. What did your hands make useful? A casserole. A ride to the pharmacy for a friend. An hour of listening. Honest work has no retirement age, and Mary has never asked to see your pay stub.

Lord, thank you for the work you let me do. Some was paid, some wasn't. Most of it nobody saw. If I feel I'm no longer needed, remind me that you still ask me to be here. Show me one person today who could use my hands, and give me the strength to say yes. Amen.



TODAY

Write three small things your hands or your time made useful this year. They can be tiny. A ride, a call, a pot of soup.

☐ DONE

Who is better off because I got up this year?

PSALM

82 — "defend the weak"; the psalm that says every honest act of help counts as work.



DAY 349

Tomorrow's Job by the Coffee Maker

Therefore, my beloved brothers, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the Lord's work, because you know that your labor is not in vain in the Lord.

1 CORINTHIANS 15:58 (WEB)

A knot stays loose when there's something small to do. People who feel useless tie knots fast. They have too much time and too little to hold.

So here's what I do. Before I sleep, I choose one job for the morning. Just one. And I set the thing itself next to the coffee maker. A stamp. A library book. A dish to return.

In the morning the coffee brews, and there's the job, looking at me like a patient dog. I don't have to decide what the day is for. It's already set out, like a clean cup.

Father, thank you for the day ahead, and for one small thing to do in it. Bless the hands that will do it. Make it quiet work, and honest work, and enough. When I feel useless, put something real in front of me. Let it be what I need as much as what someone else needs. Amen.



TODAY

Choose one small job for tomorrow. Set the thing you need for it beside your coffee maker before you go to bed tonight, so it greets you.

☐ DONE

What small, honest job is waiting for my hands right now?

PSALM

108 — "I will wake up the dawn"; the psalm of a person who gets up with a purpose.



DAY 350

The Splinter You Thought Was Out

And be kind to one another, tender hearted, forgiving each other, just as God also in Christ forgave you.

EPHESIANS 4:32 (WEB)

You told yourself you'd forgiven them. And maybe you did. Then something small touched the spot. A voice on the phone, a song, a name in conversation. And it stung again.

That doesn't mean you failed. It's like a splinter. You pulled most of it out, and a tiny piece stayed under the skin. It only hurts when pressed.

So today we don't pull harder. We look. Is it healed, sore, or still a splinter? Be honest. Don't rush the answer. Mary has seen worse, and she stayed in the room.

Lord Jesus, you know the name I put down last. You know the spot that still stings. I'm not asking to feel nothing. I'm asking to want to be free of it. Take out what I can't reach. Give me a little mercy for them, and a lot for myself. Do the work in me that I can't do. Amen.



TODAY

On a scrap of paper, write the first name of the person. Beside it write one word: healed, sore, or splinter. Be honest, then fold it.

☐ DONE

If I weren't carrying this, what would my hands be doing?

PSALM

32 — "you forgave the iniquity of my sin"; the psalm of a heart that stops hiding.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The same tide that stirred it up is still out there. A hurt forgiven once can be pressed again. Come back to it, gently, as often as it asks. That isn't failure. That's tending.



WEEK 3

Week 3

DAYS 351 TO 357

Warm water, a quiet house, an open hand, and the first words of the day. You write your rule and choose your corner.



DAY 351

Warm Water Over Your Hands

As far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us.

PSALM 103:12 (WEB)

When the old sentence rises again, and it will, you need something to do with your body. The mind alone can't talk itself out of it.

Go to the sink. Run the water warm. Hold your hands under it and let the sentence go down with the water. Not a big gesture. Just warm water, a slow breath, and three words: "Not today, Lord."

I do this myself. It sounds too simple. But a hurt lives in the hands more than we think, in the clench of a fist, the grip on a cup. When the hands soften, the heart is allowed to follow.

Lord, there it is again, that old sentence, right on time. I won't fight it with my whole strength. I'll turn on the water and give it to you. Wash it down, and wash me with it. Put the east and the west between us, as far as you say. And then help me do the dishes. Amen.



TODAY

Run warm water over your hands for one full minute the next time the old hurt rises. Say, "Not today, Lord," and let it go down the drain.

☐ DONE

Where in my body does this hurt live?

PSALM

103 — "as far as the east is from the west"; the psalm that tells how far God throws a wrong. (Changed from 35.)



DAY 352

The Quietest Sound in the House

My soul rests in God alone. My salvation is from him. He alone is my rock, my salvation, and my fortress. I will never be greatly shaken.

PSALM 62:1–2 (WEB)

Remember the heaviness that came at dawn? Let's check on it. Not by thinking. By listening.

Sit still and hear your house. The refrigerator hum. A floorboard settling. The wind on the glass. A year ago, the quiet felt like an accusation. Today, listen again. Is it any gentler?

Peace isn't a house with nothing wrong in it. It's a house where the quiet doesn't point at you. If the room is bigger than it was, even a little, then something has been undone. Take your time with the answer. Mary doesn't rush that kind of work.

Mother, I'm sitting in the quiet of my own house. Thank you that it isn't as loud as it was. Where it's still heavy, sit down beside it with me. Quiet the part of me that keeps rehearsing tomorrow. Let this stillness be a place I can come back to. Teach me to rest like a child in your lap. Amen.



TODAY

Sit for two minutes and listen to your house. Notice the quietest sound. Then say, "Thank you, Mary," for that one.

☐ DONE

Is the quiet in my house an accusation, or a rest?

PSALM

62 — "my soul rests in God alone"; chosen over 74, which is about ruins; this one is about rest. (Changed from 74.)



DAY 353

The Last Light Off

The work of righteousness will be peace, and the effect of righteousness, quietness and confidence forever. My people will live in a peaceful habitation, in safe dwellings, and in quiet resting places,

ISAIAH 32:17-18 (WEB)

Every night you do one thing without thinking. You turn off the last light. Your hand finds the switch in the dark.

Let that be the lock on the day. Hand on the switch, one breath, and one sentence: "Peace to this house." That's all. You're not asking for a miracle. You're closing the door on the worrying.

Father Jakob, long ago, in Augsburg, is said to have blessed each room this way, the last thing before bed. Whether or not that's true, it works. Ten seconds, and nobody has to see it. A day that ends with a blessing doesn't spill into the next one.

Lord, the day is done, and I'm done with it. Whatever is unfinished stays unfinished. Bless this house, and everyone who sleeps in it, near or far. Keep out the fear that comes with the dark. Keep in the little peace we have. Let the last light go out on a very quiet heart. Amen.



TODAY

Tonight, when you turn off the last light, keep your hand on the switch. Say "Peace to this house," slowly. Then turn it off.

☐ DONE

What am I willing to leave unfinished tonight?

PSALM

29 — "the LORD will bless his people with peace"; the psalm for the end of the day. (Changed from 77.)



DAY 354

Keys in an Open Hand

The LORD will fulfill that which concerns me. Your loving kindness, LORD, endures forever. Don't forsake the works of your own hands.

PSALM 138:8 (WEB)

Look at your keys. House, car, the spare you keep for a neighbor. A whole life of keeping hangs on that ring.

Surrender doesn't mean you stop locking the door. It means you stop believing that you alone keep the house. You've been the keeper for so long, maybe too long. You were allowed to be tired.

Hold the keys in your fist. Now open your hand and let them lie flat in your palm. See how they rest without your gripping? That's the whole lesson. Mary will take the other end of the ring.

Lord, I've been the one who checks the locks, the stove, the bills, the children. I'm tired of being the only keeper. Here are my keys. Here is my house. Keep what I can't. And when I take the ring back up tomorrow, remind me that my hand isn't the only one on it. Amen.



TODAY

Hold your keys tightly in your fist for a moment. Then open your hand, set them on the table, and say, "I'm not the only keeper."

☐ DONE

What would I stop checking if I believed I wasn't alone?

PSALM

138 — "the LORD will fulfill that which concerns me"; the psalm of a person who finally lets someone else carry part of it.



DAY 355

The First Words of the Day

The LORD is near to all those who call on him, to all who call on him in truth.

PSALM 145:18 (WEB)

The first thing you say each morning matters more than you think. Most of us say something to the phone, the weather, or our own back. "Oh, my knee." "Another one."

Try something else. Before your feet touch the floor, before the phone, say, "Good morning, Mary." That's it. You've handed her the day before the day gets a chance to grab you.

It's a little like greeting a friend as she comes in the door. You don't ask for anything. You only let her know you know she's there. That is surrender, kept: a greeting, every day.

Good morning, Mary. Here I am again, a bit stiff, a bit unsure. I don't know what today holds. I'm not asking to know. I'm asking to meet it with you beside me, and to say thank you at the end of it, whatever it turned out to be. Take the day before I do. Amen.



TODAY

Say it now, out loud: "Good morning, Mary." Tomorrow, say it before your feet touch the floor or your phone wakes up.

☐ DONE

What do I usually say to the day before it begins?

PSALM

145 — "the LORD is near to all who call on him"; the psalm of a person who calls first.



DAY 356

Three Lines on a Card

In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make your paths straight.

PROVERBS 3:6 (WEB)

A rule of life sounds grand. It isn't. It's what you'd do on an ordinary day if you could do it well.

Mine fits on a card. When: the morning, before the news. Where: the same chair. What: one page, one candle, one name. That's all. Notice there's no promise of feeling anything. A rule isn't a feeling. It's a place you keep returning to.

Yours should be small enough to keep on your worst day. If it takes an hour, you'll skip it. If it takes three minutes, you'll keep it with a fever. Write yours today.

Lord, I want a way of living that I can keep. Not a grand promise I'll break by the end of the month. Help me choose a few simple things, and help me return to them when I fall off. Let my days have a shape that holds me up. And when I forget, let the card on the table remind me that you haven't. Amen.



TODAY

On an index card, write three lines: when you will pray, where you will sit, and what you will do. Keep it small.

☐ DONE

What could I keep doing even on my worst day?

PSALM

119 — "your word is a lamp to my feet"; chosen over 148, since a rule of life is a way to walk, not a chorus. (Changed from 148.)



DAY 357

A Corner for Your Morning

Cause me to hear your loving kindness in the morning, for I trust in you. Cause me to know the way in which I should walk, for I lift up my soul to you.

PSALM 143:8 (WEB)

A morning you keep needs a place. Not a room. A corner. The same spot every day, so your body learns before your mind does.

Choose it today. The end of the kitchen table. The edge of the counter. The arm of the sofa. Put one candle there, and your page, and your rosary if you have one. Nothing else.

After a few weeks, you'll notice something. Your shoulders drop when you sit down there. The place starts praying before you do. That's what a kept morning feels like. It's a path worn into the floor.

Lord, this is my corner. It isn't much. A candle, a page, a few quiet minutes. But it's where I come back to you. Keep the place warm for me when I forget it. Call me back when I drift. Let every morning here be a small yes, repeated until it's simply who I am. Amen.



TODAY

Choose one spot in your home for your mornings. Set a candle and your day's page there now, so it's ready tomorrow.

☐ DONE

What would make this corner feel like mine?

PSALM

143 — "cause me to hear your loving kindness in the morning"; chosen over 149, which is about swords; this one is about mornings. (Changed from 149.)

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I let it slip once. My corner turned into a shelf for the mail. Come back to yours, even if there's dust on it. The place waits. So does she.



WEEK 4

Week 4

DAYS 358 TO 365

Teaching a child to pray, passing on a page, a blessing for the house, thanks, a letter to next year, and day 365.



DAY 358

Four Words on the Phone



Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it.

PROVERBS 22:6 (WEB)

My friend, the little ones don't need a lecture. They need one sentence, in your voice, that they can carry in a pocket.

Walt called his granddaughter a while back. She was upset about something at school. He said, "Say this with me, sweetheart: Mary, stay with me." Four words. She said them back, hiccupping. Days later, she used them before a spelling test. Walt told me it was the best phone call he'd had in years.

You don't have to be a teacher. Give them one sentence and a reason to remember who gave it.

Lord, thank you for the little voices in my life, near and far. Give me the right words when I speak to them. Make me patient with their questions and plain about my faith. I can't make them believe. But I can hand them one small sentence. Plant it deep, and let it grow where I can't see. Amen.



TODAY

Call a grandchild, or any child you love. Teach them four words to say when they're scared: "Mary, stay with me."

☐ DONE

What did someone teach me when I was small that I still say?

PSALM

89 — "with my mouth I will make known your faithfulness to all generations"; the psalm of a faith passed by mouth.



DAY 359

A Page in Your Own Hand

One generation will commend your works to another, and will declare your mighty acts.

PSALM 145:4 (WEB)

You've read a year of pages. Now give one away.

Not the whole year. One page. Pick the day that did you the most good. Then copy its prayer by hand onto plain paper. Your handwriting, slanted and shaky as it is. That's what makes it a gift.

Tom lives alone, two doors down. A while back, I left him a page like this. Days later, I saw it taped to his refrigerator, next to a coupon. "I read it with my toast," he said. He didn't say more. He didn't have to.

A handwritten prayer says one thing: someone was thinking of you.

Lord, give me the words I'd like to hand on. I'm not a writer, and my letters wobble. But let this page carry what I can't say well in person. Bless whoever reads it. Let it find them at a hard hour, and let it be short enough to read. Use my plain handwriting to say that someone is thinking of them. Amen.



TODAY

Copy one prayer from your year onto plain paper, in your own handwriting. Give it to someone, or leave it where they'll find it.

☐ DONE

Who would be braver tomorrow if they held this page?

PSALM

145 — "one generation will commend your works to another"; chosen over 150 because it is about handing on. (Changed from 150.)



DAY 360

The Names, Read Again

The gatekeeper opens the gate for him, and the sheep listen to his voice. He calls his own sheep by name and leads them out.

JOHN 10:3 (WEB)

Find your Names Page. The ink has aged a little. Some names have small ticks beside them. Some have a date. One or two you may have crossed out with tears, and I don't need you to say why.

Read them from the top. Slowly. Each one is a person you didn't give up on. That's what a year of praying looks like on paper. It doesn't look like answers. It looks like faithfulness.

Some of those names have moved closer. Some haven't, yet. Put a small cross beside the ones that have changed, however slightly. And add one more name. There is always someone.

Mary, here is my list, in my own hand. A year ago these were only names. Now they're people I've carried every day. Keep each one. For the ones who have changed, thank you. For the ones who haven't, be patient with me. And for the name I'm about to add, make room in your arms. Amen.



TODAY

Read your whole Names Page aloud. Make a small cross beside each name that has changed, and add one new name at the bottom.

☐ DONE

Which name moved the most, and what did I do?

PSALM

147 — "he calls them all by their names"; the psalm of a God who knows every name on the list. (Changed from 2.)



DAY 361

The Shoelace and the Knot

I have set the LORD always before me. Because he is at my right hand, I shall not be moved.

PSALM 16:8 (WEB)

Think of your shoelace. You tie it every morning, and you never fight it. It comes undone with one pull, because you touch it every day.

The knot that jams is the one you tied once and forgot. It sat. It dried. It gathered dust. By the time you needed it loose, it was stuck.

This whole year has been about that. A knot stays loose where the hands keep returning. Your corner. Your kettle. Your last light. Those aren't chores. They're the daily touch that keeps a knot from setting hard.

Lord, I think I understand now. It isn't about one great prayer. It's the small touch, every day. Keep me coming back to the corner, the kettle, the switch. When I forget, don't let me stay away too long. Let my hands remember where they met you. And please make the way back short. Amen.



TODAY

Sit in your morning corner for two minutes in silence, hands loose in your lap. Name the three places where you meet her each day, aloud or in your head.

☐ DONE

Which of my daily habits keeps me closest to her?

PSALM

16 — "I have set the LORD always before me"; chosen over 8, since the lesson is the daily setting before. (Changed from 8.)



DAY 362

Room to Room with a Blessing

Into whatever house you enter, first say, 'Peace be to this house.' If a son of peace is there, your peace will rest on him; but if not, it will return to you.

LUKE 10:5–6 (WEB)

Today you bless your house. Not with a priest. With your own hands and your own voice. A house that's been prayed over is a different place to wake up in.

Start at the front and go room to room. In each one, pause. Make the Sign of the Cross in the air. Say who sleeps there, or who used to, or who visits. Say, "Peace be here." You can go quickly or slowly. The house knows.

Don't skip the bathroom or the closet. God made those too. The corner you're most embarrassed about needs the blessing most.

Lord, bless this house and every room in it. Bless the table, the beds, the hall, and the corner where I pray. Bless the people who live here and the people who visit. Let it be a place where tired people rest and sad people are listened to. Keep out what harms. Keep in what is kind. Amen.



TODAY

Walk through your house, room by room. In each one, make the Sign of the Cross in the air and say, "Peace be here."

☐ DONE

Which room in my home needs the blessing most?

PSALM

121 — "the LORD will keep your going out and your coming in"; chosen over 45; the psalm for the coming and going of a household. (Changed from 45.)



DAY 363

A Thank-You With No Request



For he who is mighty has done great things for me. Holy is his name.

LUKE 1:49 (WEB)

You've asked her for so much this year. Sleep. Money. A phone call. Courage. And she answered, in ways you saw and in ways you didn't.

Today, ask for nothing. Picture your own mother at the sink with her sleeves rolled up. You'd never walk past her without saying thank you. A mother doesn't need a speech. She needs to hear it, plain.

Say it for something real: a night you slept, a bill that was smaller than you feared, a morning your hands didn't shake. Say it out loud, and slowly. She's been waiting all year for this one.

Mary, I've come to ask for nothing today. I've only come to say thank you. For the nights you sat up with me. For the days you carried what I dropped. For every small thing that went better than it might have. I don't always notice you at work. I notice now. Thank you, Mother. Amen.



TODAY

Say "Thank you, Mary" out loud. Then name one real thing from this year that you're thankful for, in a single sentence.

☐ DONE

What went better than I feared this year, and did I notice?

PSALM

9 — "I will give thanks to the LORD with my whole heart"; the psalm of plain thanks, kept from the plan.



DAY 364

Dear Next Year's Me

Behold, I will do a new thing. It springs out now. Don't you know it? I will even make a way in the wilderness, and rivers in the desert.

ISAIAH 43:19 (WEB)

Write to the person you'll be a year from now. Tell them where you are today.

Say what's still tight. Say what's loose. Say what you're proud of, even if it's small. Tell them the name of someone you're praying for. Tell them where the corner is, in case they forget.

Then tell them one thing you know is true: "You weren't alone." Fold it and slip it inside the front cover. A year from now, when it falls into your lap, you'll see that the one who wrote it was afraid and prayed anyway. You'll be kinder to yourself.

Lord, here is a year of mornings in your hands. I don't know what the next one holds. I don't need to. Walk ahead of the person I'll become, and wait for me at every turn. Let the one who reads this letter find that it was written in trust. And let it be true, whatever comes, that I did not walk alone. Amen.



TODAY

On a sheet of paper, write a letter to yourself a year from now. Fold it and slip it inside the front cover.

☐ DONE

What do I most want next year's me to remember?

PSALM

31 — "my times are in your hand"; chosen over 14; the psalm of trusting the years ahead to God. (Changed from 14.)

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A door you opened this year won't close on its own. But it can swing shut if no one holds it. Come back to your corner tomorrow. Leave it open, and she will keep walking through.



DAY 365

Three Hundred Sixty-Five



He heals the broken in heart,
and binds up their wounds.

PSALM 147:3 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. You're awake in the same house, with the same body, and probably the same pile of mail. On the first morning I told you I wouldn't fix any of it. I haven't.

Here's what did change. In the first minute of the day you know where your hands go. The page. Her name. The kettle, the corner, the switch. A knot that's touched every day can't set hard, and you've touched yours three hundred and sixty-five times.

The bills will come again, and so will the long nights. Today, sing a little. Even badly.

Mary, Undoer of Knots, here are my three hundred and sixty-five mornings. Some were bright, and some I only half showed up for. Thank you for every one. Thank you for the knots you loosened, and for the ones you showed me how to loosen myself. Stay at my table, my bed, my phone, and my door. I'll keep coming back. Please keep being there. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle. Say out loud, "Three hundred sixty-five." Then name the nine knots, one by one, and thank her for each.

☐ DONE

What do I now know how to do with my hands?

PSALM

150 — "let everything that has breath praise Yah"; the psalm that closes the year. The Verse mirrors Day 1 (Psalm 147:3), on purpose.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

She doesn't tire, and she hasn't left. But you can forget she's there. Tomorrow, say good morning to her before you touch the phone. The page ends here. The habit doesn't have to.

CLOSING OF BOOK 12 · THE KNOT THAT DOES NOT TIE AGAIN

LOOKING BACK

Four questions. Take your time. Tick the box when you have answered.

[ ] Which of the nine knots feels loosest today, and what keeps it that way?

[ ] Which small habit do I touch every day without being asked?

[ ] Whose name on my Names Page changed me the most?

[ ] What will I do tomorrow morning, when there is no next page?

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

My friend,

You've reached the bottom of the last page. I'd like to sit with you a minute before you close it.

A year ago, you couldn't have told me what a morning with Mary would feel like. Now you can. It feels like a corner of the kitchen. A kettle. A name said out loud. A light switched off with a blessing. Small things. They are the whole secret.

I promised you the truth on the first day, so here it is on the last. Your life will not be free of knots. Thread is thread. A bill will come. A phone will stay quiet. A night will find you awake. But a knot that is touched every day doesn't set hard. No knot can tighten while a hand keeps returning to it. You know the end of the thread now. You know whose hands to put yours into.

Father Jakob, long ago in Augsburg, never wrote one grand sentence about this. He came back every morning. So did Father Matthias, who sent me the pages. So have I, on tired days and bad days. So have you.

Don't put these pages in a drawer. I did that once. Keep them by your chair. Begin again tomorrow, if you like. A second year isn't repetition. It's a deeper well.

Light the last candle. Say the names. Say "Amen," and mean the small, daily kind.

She is still at your table. She always was.

— Father Lucas

THE SEAL OF THE MONTH

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS · BOOK 12 · THE KNOT THAT DOES NOT TIE AGAIN

Date:

THE CANDLE OF THE MONTH: NO KNOT TIES AGAIN

Light the candle. Say the names on your Names Page, slowly, one by one.

Let the flame burn while you sit in your corner. Then blow it out with an "Amen."



THIS CERTIFIES THAT

NAME

The Year of Untied Knots

CERTIFICATE OF THE UNTIED YEAR

This certifies that

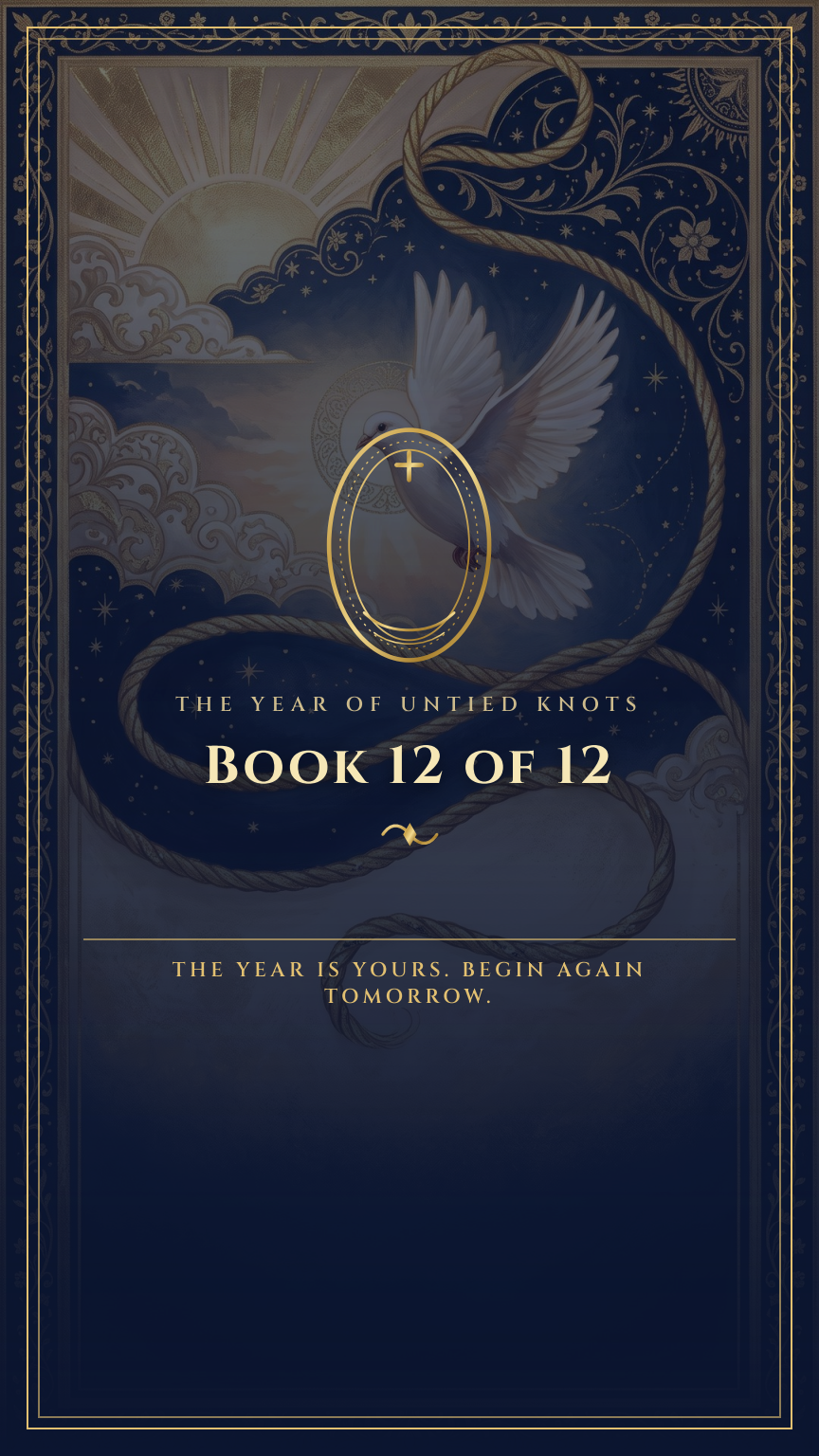
"What was tied, she loosened. What was loosened, you kept."

Date:

DATE

Father L

AUGSBUR



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 12 of 12

THE YEAR IS YOURS. BEGIN AGAIN TOMORROW.